

Worst Possible Idea

Generate terrible ideas, then invert them

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Worst Possible Idea is a reverse-brainstorming technique: the group deliberately generates the **worst** solutions to a problem, then flips each into its opposite or extracts the useful kernel. Removing the pressure to be good unlocks fluency and surfaces surprising strong ideas.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

A staple of design-thinking facilitation, taught by IDEO, the d.school and the Interaction Design Foundation.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Fear of proposing a bad idea suppresses participation. Inverting the goal makes 'bad' safe and even fun, freeing quieter members and breaking fixation.

HOW IT IS USED

Brainstorm the worst ideas for a few minutes, then for each terrible idea ask what its opposite would be, or what hidden insight it reveals, harvesting the inversions.

WHEN IT IS USED

Ideation, especially to warm up a group or rescue a stalled brainstorm.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Facilitators and creative teams.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

It exploits the **psychology of permission** — lowering the stakes to raise output — a playful complement to rule-based brainstorming.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Brainstorming *Slibrary 7*

SCAMPER *Slibrary 1*

Six Thinking Hats *Slibrary 2*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Dam, R. and Siang, T. (2020) 'Learn How to Use the Best Ideation Methods', *Interaction Design Foundation*.

Kelley, T. and Kelley, D. (2013) *Creative Confidence*. New York: Crown Business.

FIGURE 1 · REVERSE BRAINSTORMING

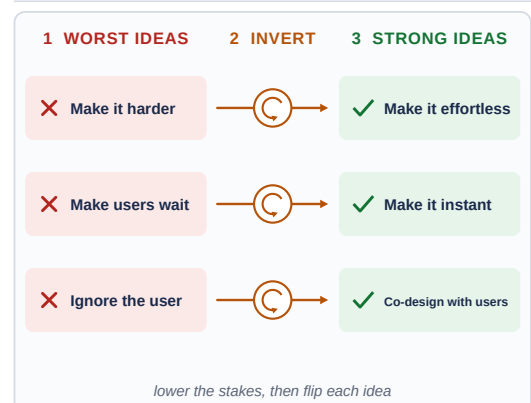


Figure 1. Deliberately bad ideas are flipped into their opposites to reveal strong concepts (illustrative pairs).